

Strategic bombing
A group of B-17s from the 398th Bombardment Group fly a bombing run to Neumunster, Germany, on 8 April 1945. By that stage of the war, Luftwaffe fighters had ceased to pose a serious threat to the Flying Fortresses.

> "THE TERROR STARTS ON THE NIGHT BEFORE THE MISSION … ANXIETY, DREAMS … EXCUSES NOT TO FLY … LOOSE BOWELS, SHAKING AND SILENCE."
>
> **HOWARD JACKSON**, BOMBARDIER, USAAF 15TH AIR FORCE

A chorus of groans and curses greeted the announcement of a target deep inside Germany. While ground crews prepared the aircraft, the airmen tucked into breakfast, if they had the stomach for it. Take-off was usually at around dawn, the B-17s lifting off at 30-second intervals, using the full length of the runway burdened with a maximum load of bombs and fuel. The bombers then had to climb to the assembly point and take their place in the formation (no simple matter) before heading towards the coast of Occupied Europe. The tail gunners and ball-turret gunner did not occupy their positions until after take-off. The ball-turret gunner had the most unenviable post in the aircraft. Squashed into a foetal position underneath the belly, he did not even have room to wear a parachute. But no one had a comfortable flight. Travelling in an unpressurized aircraft at 7,600m (25,000ft), men were exposed to temperatures as low as -45°C. Survival on flights lasting many hours depended on wearing oxygen masks and electrically heated flying suits. There were casualties from frostbite and deaths when the oxygen supply failed.

Once they travelled beyond the range of their fighter escorts, the bombers came under attack from swarms of Messerschmitts and Focke-Wulfs flown by Luftwaffe pilots. One advantage of flying in tight formation was that the enemy fighters were exposed to the collective fire of the entire formation's gun turrets – however, it also meant that when under fire themselves, pilots were unable to take evasive action. Boredom and discomfort were instantly replaced by fear and adrenaline-soaked excitement as the gunners strove to hit their fast-moving adversaries. Many would forget their training, opening fire at too long a range, or failing to use their sights correctly. The waist and top turret gunners would soon be standing in heaps of spent cartridge cases. Some German fighters attacked from directly ahead, where the bomber's only defence consisted of hand-held guns operated by the bombardier and navigator. B-17s began to fall from the sky in flames with parachutes blossoming as airmen jumped for their lives. Approaching the target through heavy flak was the most nerve-racking part of the entire mission. In the lead aircraft of the formation the bombardier took control of the aircraft, using his Norden bomb-sight linked to an autopilot. The whole formation had to fly straight and steady for the bomb run, making a perfect target for the German anti-aircraft gunners below. When the B-17 lurched upwards as the bombs were released, every member of the crew would feel a surge of relief. But getting home was, of course, not necessarily any easier than the outward journey. The pilot was often nursing a damaged aircraft with wounded or dead personnel on board. As survivors landed back at base around mid-afternoon, losses were tallied and the wounded carried off for treatment.



Flak helmet
This steel flak helmet was worn to protect against enemy fire. It had a special coating that prevented the crewman's fingers freezing to the metal at high altitude.



Sperry turret gunner
A gunner squeezes into the ball turret under the belly of a B-17E, watched by fellow crew members. The gunner never entered his position before take-off, instead climbing down into the turret from inside the aircraft once in the air.

COPING AND SURVIVAL

A bomber crew's standard tour of duty initially consisted of 25 combat missions, although this was subsequently increased to 35. The received wisdom was that a man had a one in three chance of surviving his tour. In some unfortunate formations, though, the odds were far worse. One squadron flying out of East Anglia in 1943 had lost seven of its nine original crews by the